



UNDERSTANDING LEARNING DIFFICULTIES

Breaking barriers, building a bright future for
everyone

Learning Difficulties are more common than we think

Millions of children and adults worldwide navigate learning differences every day. Understanding the scope helps us build better support systems

1 in 5

Students Affected
Approximately
20% of students
have learning
difficulties
globally

780M

**Estimated
individuals
with
difficulties
the globe**
**living
learning
across**

15%

US Population
**Over 48 million
Americans have
some form of
learning difficulty**

6.7M

School-AgeChildren
**Students receiving
special education
services in the United
States**

Dyslexia

A Learning Difficulty that Affects Reading and Language-Based Processing Skills



- 3-7% of South Africa's Population has Dyslexia and 20% show symptoms.
- Dyslexia is the most common learning difficulty in children

DYSLEXIA CAN IMPACT:

- Word recognition
- Spelling
- Associating letters with the sounds they make
- Understanding what one reads.
- Pronouncing written words

20%

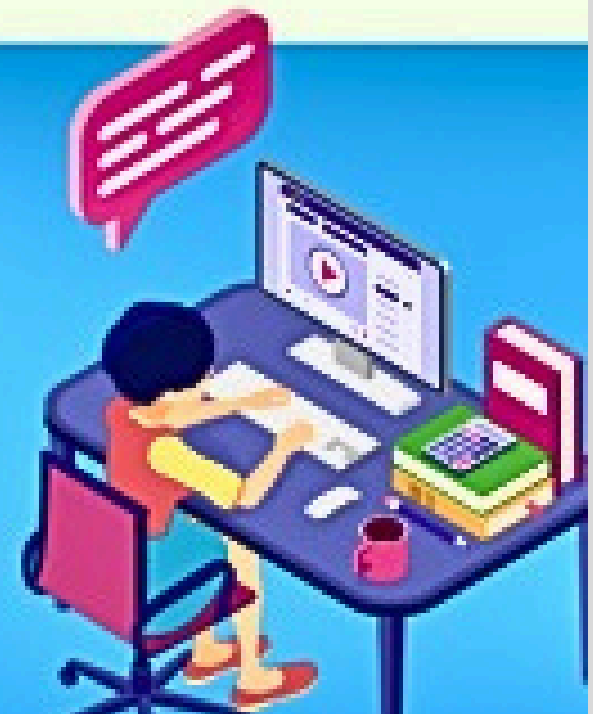
1 in 5
Kids Have
Dyslexia

Not Lazy

Because reading involves more decoding for kids with dyslexia, it takes a lot more energy. Kids with dyslexia may say that reading gives them headaches or makes them feel tired. Finding the format that works best for them can help.

Not Just Dyslexia

Kids with dyslexia also often have ADHD and vice versa. 15 to 40% of kids with Dyslexia also have ADHD.



Dyscalculia

A Learning Difficulty That Affects the Ability to Understand Numbers and Learn Math Facts

Some Symptoms Can Include:

- Difficulty understanding quantities
- Challenges with basic arithmetic
- Trouble with time and money concepts

Dyscalculia affects 4% to 6% of the population worldwide.

Myth

People with dyscalculia can't have careers that involve math.

Fact

Good instruction, personal practice, and workplace accommodations can help make jobs that involve math more accessible to people with dyscalculia.

Learn more at idaamerica.org

ADHD

A common neurodevelopmental disorder that affects children and adults, characterized by persistent patterns of inattention, hyperactivity, or impulsivity.



About 30-50% of people diagnosed in childhood continue to have symptoms in adulthood and 2-5% of adults have the condition

Research show that 16-3% of adults with ADHD also experience depression

A D H D

MYTHS

vs.

REALITY

- ADHD only impacts children.
- ADHD isn't a thing. We all get distracted.
- ADHD? They're just being lazy.
- If they tried harder, it wouldn't be a problem.

- Nope! Adults can live with ADHD, too.
- People with ADHD get distracted more often and with more consequences.
- It's not that they don't want to do something. It's that they can't!
- People with ADHD are often trying very hard — just with less results to show for their efforts.

ADHD SYMPTOMS IN KIDS



INATTENTIVE

- ☁ Forgetful
- ✓ Easily distracted
- Avoids focus tasks



HYPERACTIVE

- ✋ Fidgets & squirms
- 💬 Talks non-stop
- Blurts out

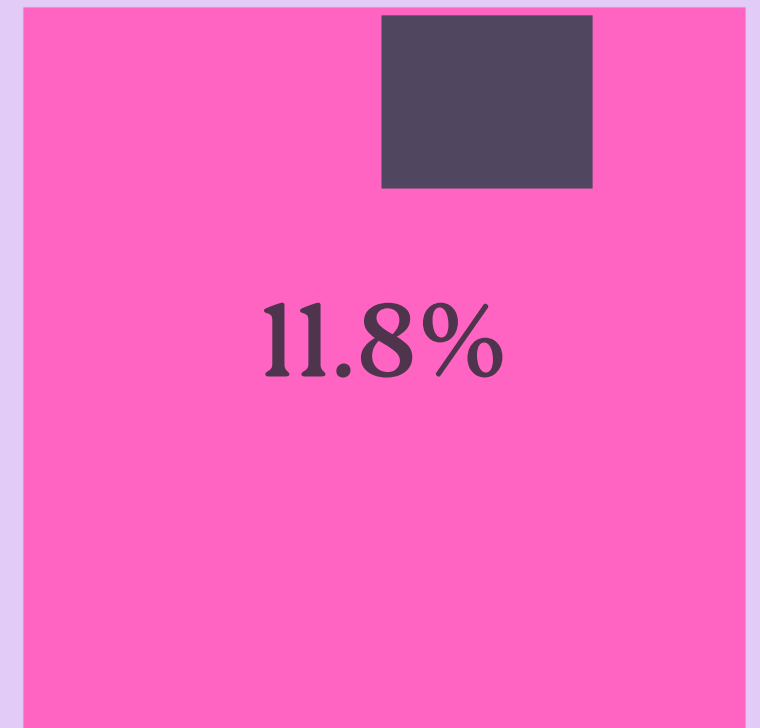


IMPULSIVE

- ! Interrupts others
- ↗ Takes risks
- 🕒 Can't wait turn

The Hidden Crises: The Awareness Gap

While learning difficulties don't discriminate, access to diagnosis and support certainly does. Communities with fewer resources face the greatest challenges in identifying and addressing learning differences.



Never diagnosed.
Students in rural areas who are left unidentified

Underserved Communities Face Barriers

- **Limited access:** Fewer specialists and diagnostic resources in low income areas
- **Delayed diagnosis:** Children in underprivileged communities are identified 2-3 years later on average
- **Language barriers:** Non-native English speakers often misdiagnosed or overlooked
- **Cost concerns:** Comprehensive evaluations can cost be expensive without medical aid
- **Stigma:** Cultural misconceptions prevent families from seeking help

Why early detection changes everything

The window for intervention matters. When learning difficulties are identified early, children develop strategies and confidence that last a life time. Research shows the brain's plasticity during childhood makes early intervention especially powerful.

Ages 3-5: Critical Window

Pre-reading skills and early math concepts develop. Early screening identifies red flags.

1

Ages 9-12: Strategy Building

Students learn compensation strategies and self-advocacy skills for long-term success.

3

Ages 6-8: Optimal Intervention

Brain plasticity at peak.
Targeted support yields strongest results and builds confidence.

2

Teen Years: Self Advocacy

Students understand their learning style and can articulate their needs effectively

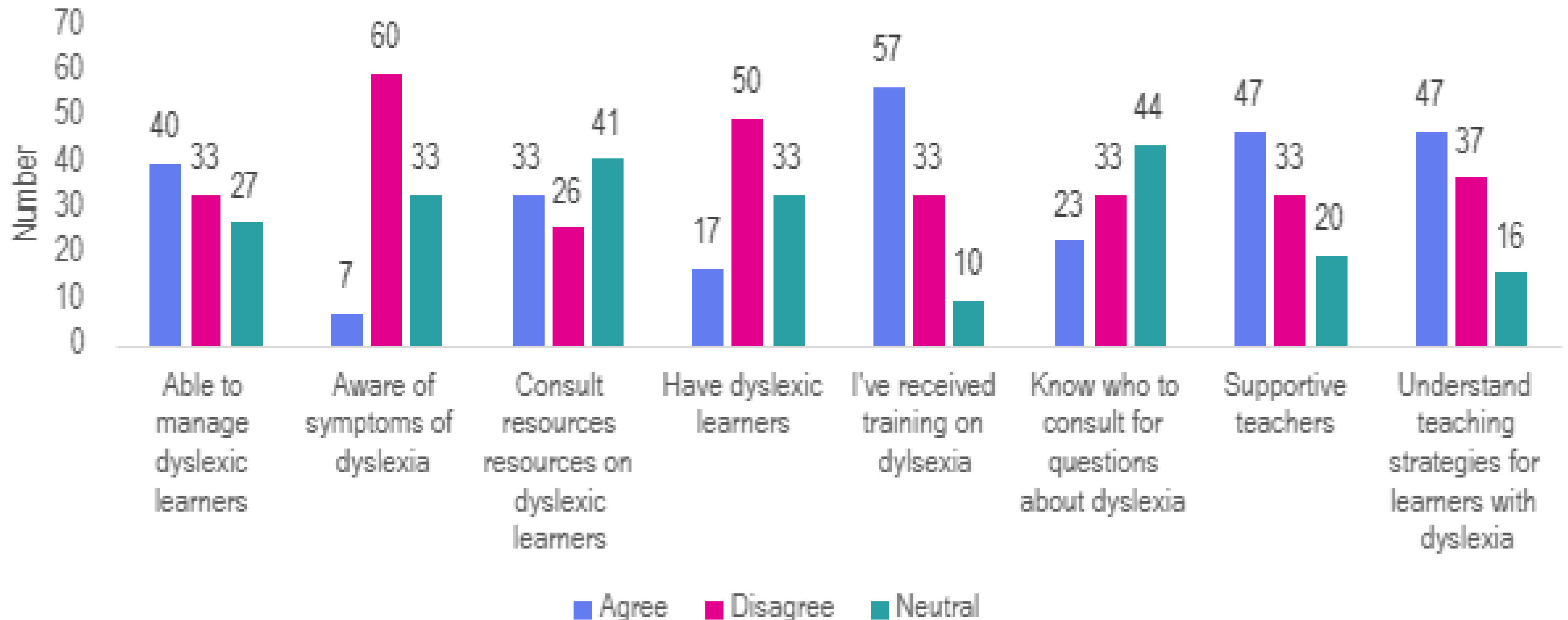
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The Research Is Clear: Children who receive intervention before age 8 are 3-4 times more likely to reach grade-level proficiency compared to those identified later.

Teacher Awareness

The way teachers navigate teaching and learning within reading difficulties brought about by dyslexia



WHY TEACHERS NEED AWARENESS TRAINING

Teachers are on the front lines of identification and support. Yet many receive minimal training on learning difficulties during their education. Comprehensive teacher awareness transforms classroom outcomes. Primary school teachers play a big role in early identification of learners with with learning difficulties and their awareness of dyslexia would be of assistance in the support of learners with LD's



What trained teachers can do

- Spot early warning signs before students fall significantly behind
- Implement evidence-based strategies that benefit all learners, not just those with LD
- Create inclusive environments where differences are understood and celebrated
- Communicate effectively with parents about concerns and progress
- Advocate for appropriate accommodations and specialized services

Breaking Down Parents' Misconceptions

Misunderstandings about learning difficulties prevent many children from getting help. Let's replace myths with facts to empower parents to advocate effectively for their children.

Myth : “My child is just lazy or not trying hard enough”

Fact: Learning difficulties are neurobiological differences. Children with LD often work twice as hard to achieve the same results. Effort isn't the issue they need different strategies.

Myth: “A diagnosis means my child is not smart”

Fact: LD has nothing to do with intelligence. Many individuals with learning disabilities have average or above-average IQs. Richard Branson, Steven Spielberg and Whoopi Goldberg were all diagnosed with dyslexia.

Myth: “They will grow out of it”

Fact: Learning difficulties are lifelong, but with proper support, individuals develop strategies to succeed. Early intervention prevents years of struggle and builds crucial confidence

Myth: "ADHD is just an excuse for bad behavior or poor parenting"

Fact: ADHD is a neuro developmental disorder with clear brain differences in areas controlling attention and impulse control. It's caused by genetics and brain chemistry—not parenting, sugar, or screen time.

Research indicates that the lack of empowerment of the key stakeholders such as parents impedes the drive towards a thriving inclusive education system.

Removing the Stigma Around Learning Difficulties

STIGMA SILENCES CHILDREN, PREVENTS EARLY INTERVENTION, AND PERPETUATES SHAME. IT'S TIME TO REFRAME THE CONVERSATION AROUND LEARNING DIFFICULTIES

Language Matters

Say "has dyslexia" not "suffers from." Use person-first language. Words shape perceptions and self-esteem.

Celebrate Strengths

Individuals with LDs often excel in creativity, problem solving and innovative thinking. Highlight abilities, not just challenges.

Share Stories

Visibility normalizes learning differences. When successful people openly discuss their LD, it reduces shame and builds hope

Educate Communities

Schools, workplaces and communities need accurate information. Awareness campaigns change attitudes and create inclusive environments.

Success Stories: From Diagnosis to Achievement

Learning difficulty don't define potential. With proper support, individuals with LD thrive in every field imaginable. Here are real examples that prove diagnosis and support unlock extraordinary possibilities



Mellisa Titus

Dyslexia : UWCBComGraduate

Diagnosed with severe dyslexia in grade 4, Mellisa graduated summa cum laude with BCom from UWC



Emma King

Dyscalculia : Mathematician

Emma King is an award-winning mathematician with a PhD who has dyscalculia.



Raven Baxter

ADHD: Molecular Biologist and Science Communicator

Diagnosed at age 6. She views her ADHD as a creative advantage and has earned recognition on Forbes 30 Under 30 in Science and Fortune's 40 Under 40 in Health, she uses her unique style to make science accessible through viral educational content.

A Call To Help

Parents & Schools

01

WATCH FOR EARLY SIGNS

Difficulty with reading, numbers, attention, or coordination. Trust your instincts, early observation matters.

02

SEEK PROFESSIONAL ASSESSMENT

Contact educational psychologists or specialists. Comprehensive evaluations to identify specific needs

03

ADVOCATE FOR ACCOMMODATIONS

Ensure learners receive the necessary support and modifications.

04

CELEBRATE STRENGTHS

Focus on abilities, not just challenges. Build confidence through encouragement and success experiences.

